Steam Games:
Price, Popularity, and Value

*A Martini Glass data story about **how pricing shapes attention** on Steam, and where it does not.*

Presenter: Jiazhi (Kenny) Sun, Shaokang Xie

CONTEXT

Why pricing matters now ?

The market is crowded, prices are rising, and visibility is scarce.

- Steam hosted **117,881** total games by late 2025, with **18,691** new releases added in 2024.
- In 2025, 20,282 games launched on Steam, but only 608 reached 1,000 user reviews — a success rate of just 2.99%.
- The average Steam game price reached $16.84 in 2025. Indie titles usually sit at $4.99–$14.99, while AAA releases average $59.99 at launch.

Pricing a **strategic choice**.

117,881

Total games on Steam

18,691

New games in 2024

2.99%

2025 releases that crossed 1k reviews

$16.84

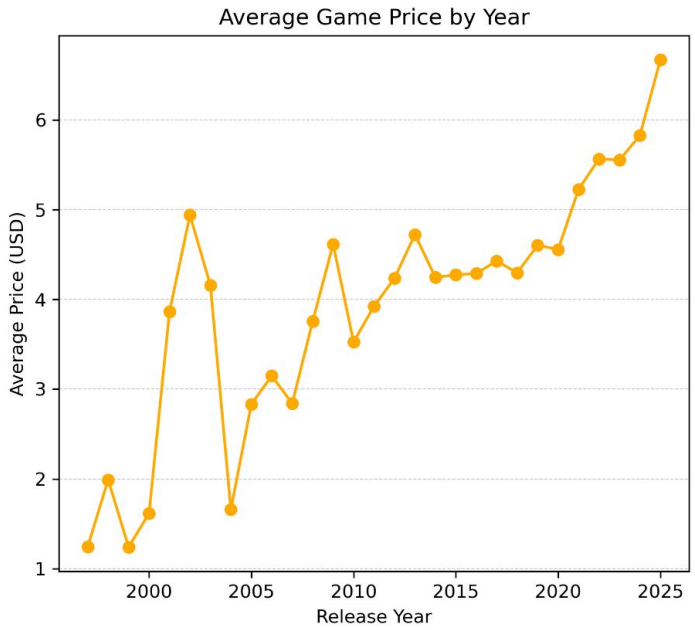
Average price of the successful games in steam

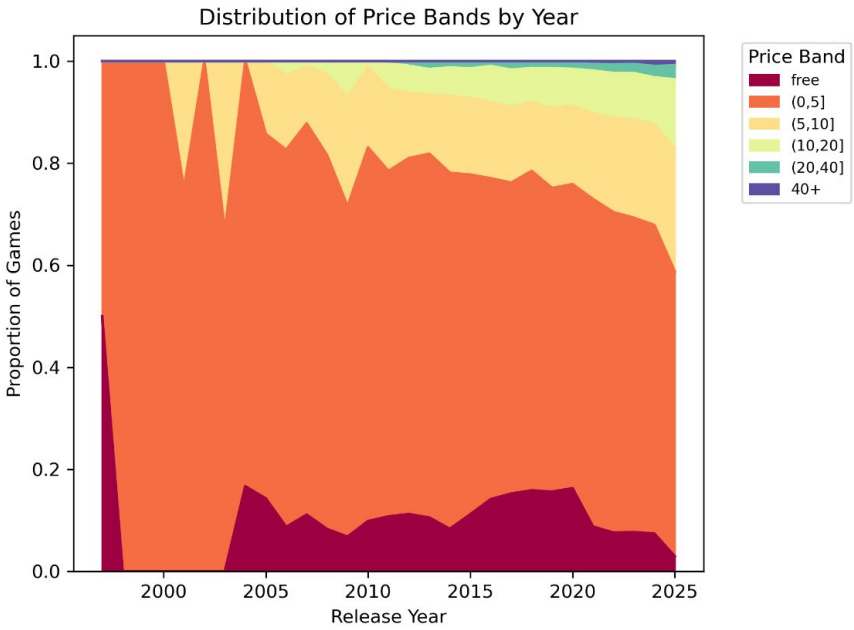
METHOD

One question, five guided views

1. **Trend view:** Is Steam drifting toward higher price bands over time?
2. **Scatter:** Do more expensive games actually attract more concurrent players?
3. **Boxplot:** Which price tier has the strongest typical popularity, not just rare outliers?
4. **Genre value:** Which genres convert price into player attention most efficiently?
5. **Spiral view:** Can we summarize time, price, popularity, and sentiment in one image?

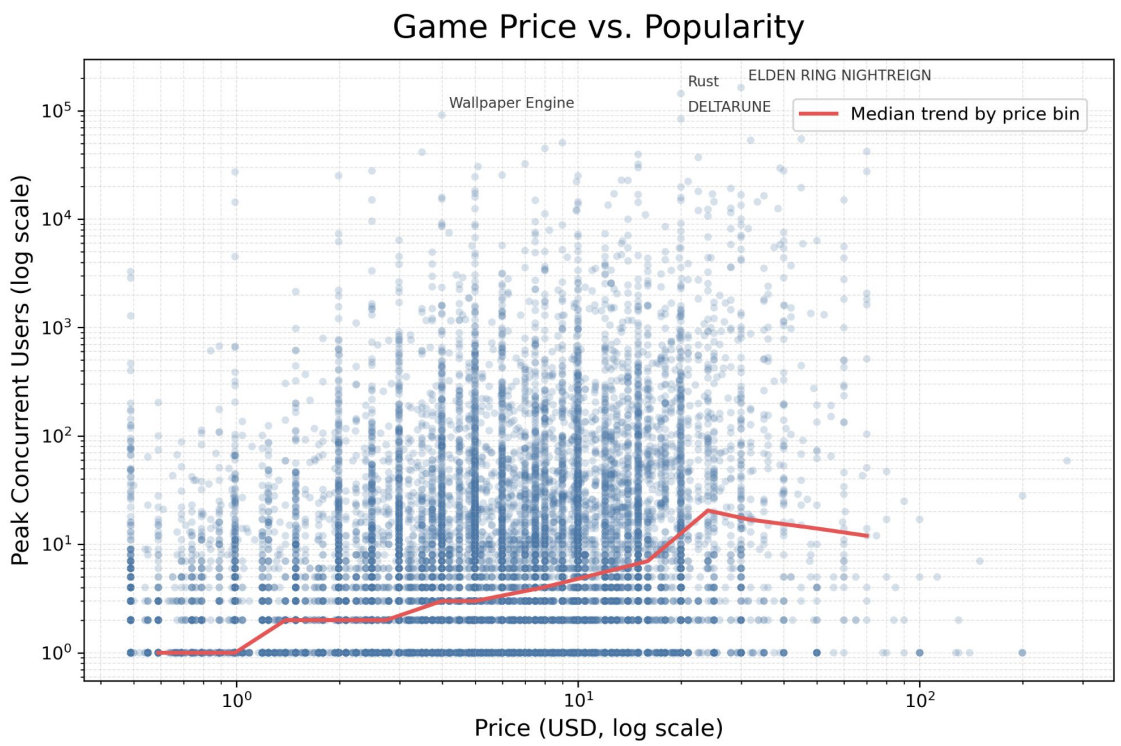
Steam is slowly drifting toward higher price bands





- This is not just a price increase. It is a composition shift: fewer cheap titles, more games in the $5-20 range.

Price alone does not explain popularity



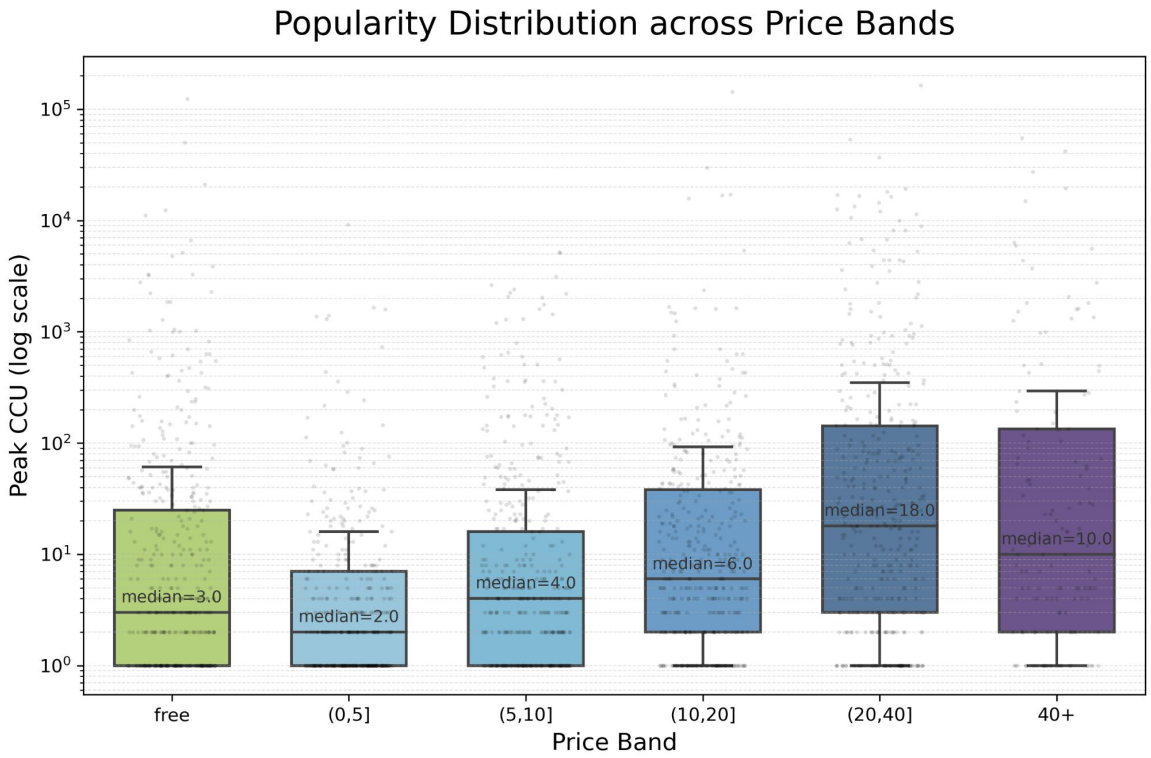
What stands out

- Most titles cluster in the bottom-left: cheap and lightly played.
- Typical attention rises into the mid-price range, but the relationship is weak and noisy.
- Breakout hits exist at very different prices.

Key Takeaway

Price may help position a game, but price alone does not create a hit.

The typical game performs best in the upper mid-price tier



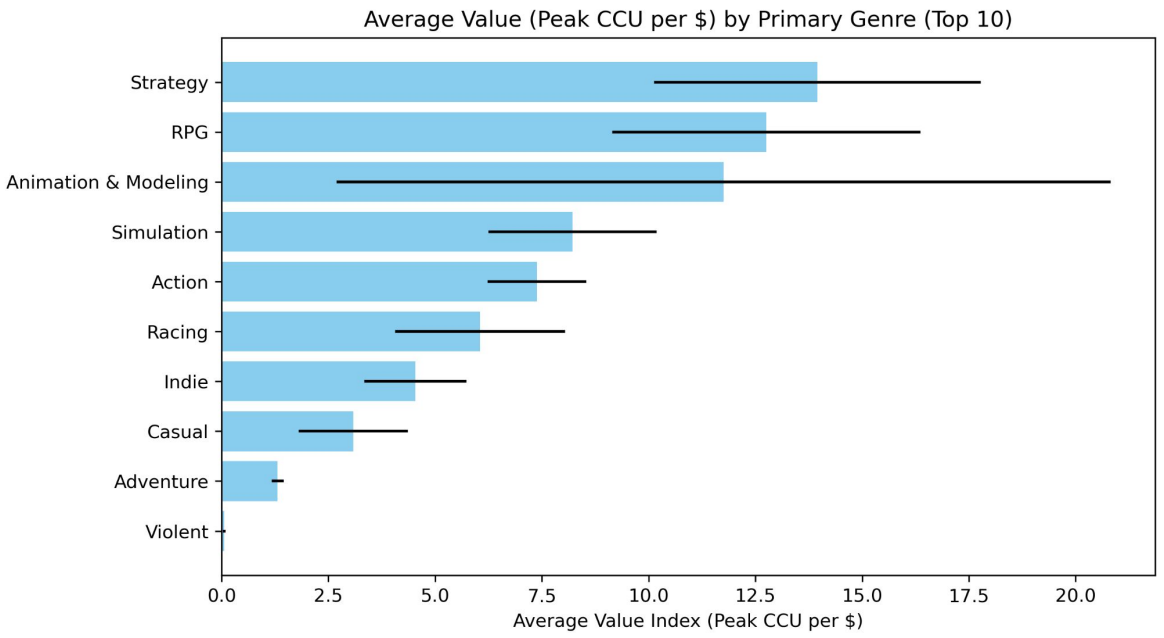
What stands out

- Free games vary widely, but their typical popularity is low.
- The $20-40 band has the highest median Peak CCU.
- The $40+ tier still contains major hits, but not a stronger typical median.

Key Takeaway

Premium pricing helps up to a point; the upper mid-tier looks strongest.

Attention per dollar varies sharply by genre



What stands out

- Strategy and RPG rank highest on Peak CCU per dollar.
- Animation & Modeling also scores high, but with much wider uncertainty.
- This indicates that price converts into attention differently across genres.

Key Takeaway

Once price alone stops explaining popularity, genre becomes the next lens.

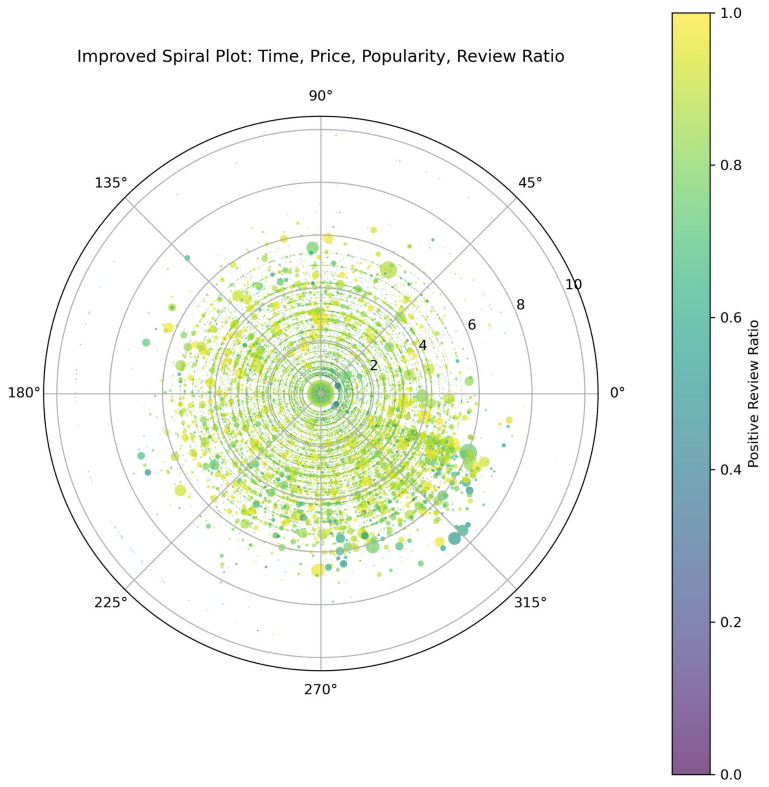
A holistic view: time, price, popularity, and sentiment

What stands out

- Time rotates around the circle, while price moves outward from the center.
- Most titles cluster near the center, showing a dense low-price core.
- Larger and warmer points appear across the spiral, suggesting breakout attention and generally positive review sentiment at many price levels.

Key Takeaway

The spiral does not replace the earlier charts; it brings them together in one visual memory.



So what does price actually buy?

Not guaranteed visibility

Hits appear at low, mid, and high prices.

Stronger typical performance

The $20-40 tier has strongest median Peak CCU.

Category fit matters

Pricing works better in some genres.

Broadly positive sentiment

Positive reviews appear across price levels, particu-larly among popular games.

Strategic Takeawy

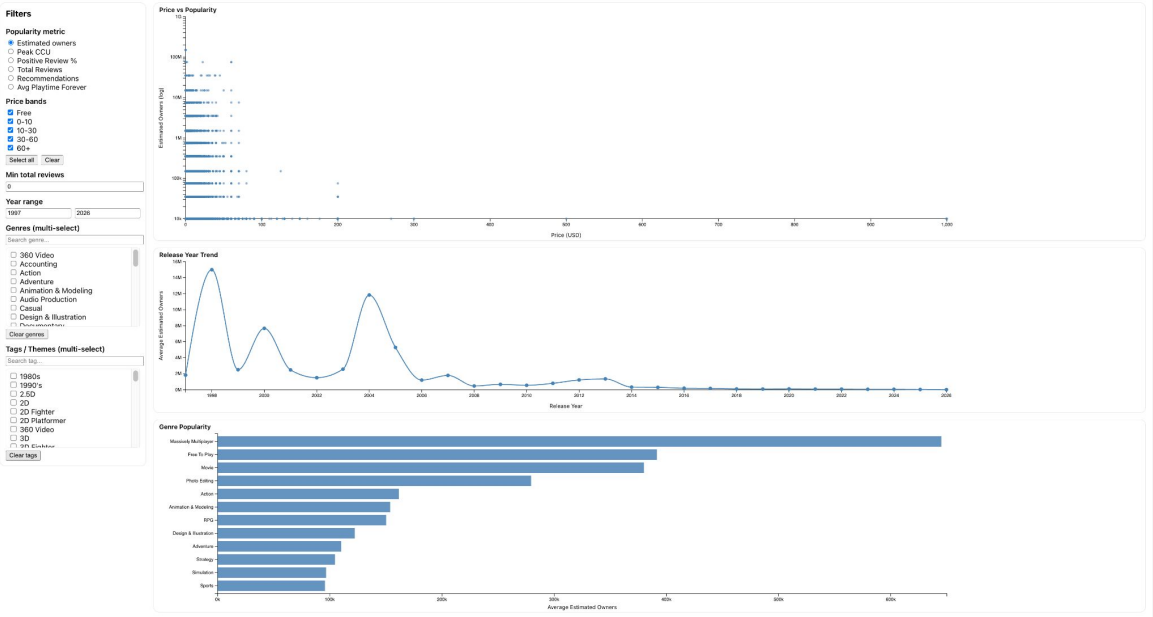
The best story is not “free beats paid” or “AAA beats indie.”

It is: **price works differently depending on context.**

Open exploration: what to explore next

What to do next

- Filter the scatter by genre, year, or price band to see whether the pattern still holds.
- Swap Peak CCU for owners or review count to test whether the story depends on the popularity metric.
- Compare individual titles within each band to find the games that break the overall pattern.
- ……



This is where the guided story opens up:
the audience can now test, refine, or challenge the narrative for themselves.